

Interviewing Students Who Don't Speak English

The official language of ISEF is English. Some ISEF finalists do not speak English. Some finalists speak *some* English, but feel uncomfortable conducting the interview entirely in English. For example, they may listen to questions in English, but respond in their native language. All finalists for whom English is not their native language have the option to request an interpreter. In all circumstances, treat this like any other interview.

We Have an Interpreter. What Do I Do?

When an interpreter is present, acknowledge them at the beginning of the interview, but then turn your full attention to the student. Do not direct your questions to the interpreter, but instead, face the student. Speak to the student; listen to the interpreter. Most interpreters will stand out of the way so as not to obstruct the judge's view of the student or display board. If they get in the way, politely ask the interpreter to move.

Please recognize that when interpreters are necessary, communication will be slower than with native English speakers. Consequently, you must focus your interview even more than usual to make sure that you get answers to all of your questions in the allotted time.

Do We Have to Conduct the Interview in English?

No. Judges who speak the same language as the student are free to conduct the interview in that language, even if an interpreter is present. Use whichever language is most productive for you and the student to communicate.

We Need an Interpreter, but We Don't Have One. What Do I Do?

Finalists who need an interpreter are required to request one in advance because it takes time for the ISEF Volunteer Manager to recruit the large number required in a large number of different languages. ISEF makes every effort to accommodate student needs. Unfortunately, sometimes students are overconfident in their language ability or simply fail to make a request. As well, the number of interpreters for a particular language is occasionally insufficient to cover all needs in all judging periods. The reason is unimportant to you as a judge.

If a necessary interpreter is not present, go to the Hub to ask for one. If one is available, bring them with you back to the student. If an interpreter will only be available later, you may return in a mutually free period to interview the student with the interpreter present.

Points of Emphasis

1. Face and speak directly to the student; listen to the interpreter.
2. If you need an interpreter, go to The Hub.
3. If you and the student can communicate better in a different language, use it.